previously held particles together in atoms and nuclei can no longer function.

Maybe it’s for the best that you don’t see it coming.

As dramatic as the process sounds from a bird’s-eye view, if you happen to be standing nearby when the bubble appears, you won’t notice it. Something coming at you at the speed of light is invisible—any little glint warning you of its approach arrives at the same time as the thing itself. There is no possible way to see it coming, or even to know that anything has gone wrong. If it approaches you from below, there will be a couple of nanoseconds during which your feet no longer exist while your brain still thinks it is looking at them. Fortunately, the process is also entirely painless: at no point will your nerve impulses be able to catch up with your disintegration by the bubble. It’s a mercy, really.

Of course, the bubble doesn’t stop with you. Any planet or star within its ever-expanding radius suffers the same fate, equally oblivious to what’s coming. Entire galaxies are engulfed and obliterated. The true vacuum cancels the universe entirely. The only regions able to escape are those that lie so far away that the accelerated expansion of the universe keeps them beyond the bubble’s horizon forever.

In fact, it’s entirely possible that, as we sit here now, calmly drinking our tea, vacuum decay has already occurred. Maybe we’re lucky and the bubble is beyond our cosmic horizon, swallowing up galaxies we would never have known. Or maybe it is, cosmically speaking, right next door, quietly approaching with relativistic stealth, destined to catch us unawares, between breaths.